

PUBLIC SUBMISSION

As of: March 21, 2025
Received: March 15, 2025
Status: [REDACTED]
Tracking No. m8a-zkop-iu94
Comments Due: March 15, 2025
Submission Type: API

Docket: NSF_FRDOC_0001

Recently Posted NSF Rules and Notices.

Comment On: NSF_FRDOC_0001-3479

Request for Information: Development of an Artificial Intelligence Action Plan

Document: NSF_FRDOC_0001-DRAFT-5945

Comment on FR Doc # 2025-02305

Submitter Information

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[REDACTED]

General Comment

From:

Eric Watkins

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I'm unsure if this will fall on deaf ears or not. I worry I may be deluding myself that anyone actually cares. I'm hoping that for once, someone who claims to be champions of small business will actually do something that benefits a small business.

My wife & I make original designs & the like for t-shirts, stickers, and more. We've worked hard on this for a long time. Put a lot of effort and energy into making items we are proud of. We took all the correct steps to make sure our unique designs would be protected from piracy and theft.

The AI systems made by Big Tech companies like OpenAI (Microsoft) and Google threaten to destroy thousands of American small businesses like mine with their recent demand to create special carve outs in copyright law.

AI systems can only be produced by first training on work made by people. My unique work, and the work of hundreds of thousands of other everyday American creators are taken and fed into these AI systems without our consent or any compensation. They ingest our work, reassemble it, and then sell it back to our clients – directly competing with us and cutting us out of the marketplace.

They are stealing from us. Plain and simple. They're looking for you to legalize their thievery.

Please, don't let this happen. Please don't create new copyright exemptions allowing Big Tech companies to exploit and steal from creators and everyday Americans without permission, compensation, or transparency.

This administration's AI Action Plan should focus not on giving away creator content to Big Tech companies, but rather on ensuring a fair marketplace with competition:

First, the government should ensure that creators and everyday Americans give effective and clearly labeled consent options, so that we can decide when and where our work is used by AI systems.

Second, the AI Action Plan should encourage a robust licensing marketplace, so that the incentive to create for small businesses is preserved. Our work has immense economic value, so the value generated by that work should accrue to the original creators, not just Big Tech. Why should Google and Microsoft be allowed to steal from me?

Finally, the AI Action Plan should require transparency from Big Tech companies, requiring them to disclose what material is in their training datasets, and label what content is AI generated. Giving them the ability to pilfer from me like a thief in the night without

consequences kills my small business.

I know I'm not the only one who feels like this. Hundreds of thousands of other small business people, creators, & artists want to protect the hard work they've done over the years. Please do not turn the years of hard labor I've put into our small business into yet another give away to Big Tech corporations.

Thank you.